

Ennodius 502

Libellus pro synodo — the physician-objection and the hereditas innocentiae (CSEL 6, pp. 294–295)

Yet to your preamble you have appended, most aptly, a divine example, which is composed of such well-squared phrases that you would think Chrysippus himself was holding the [drawing-]line in it: *God says to the sinner: Why do you declare my statutes?* To this saying, stitching on as it were an apostrophe against the priests: “Since he is reckoned the vicar of the blessed apostle Peter, you forbid his chief-physician to bring medicine to his body: how then do you refuse to furnish healing to his soul?” Whether, in matters divine, this is a great absurdity or the greatest cause for lamentation, I do not know. You seek care for another’s fever; you desire that a remedy be applied to a fainting soul; and, set at the very nearness of death, forgetful of yourselves, you busy yourselves about another’s salvation. What if that word were truly spoken to you by the prophet: *Is it a small thing that you are troublesome to men — you are troublesome to my God also?* and again: *Physician, heal yourself?* But of this elsewhere. [[p. 295]] We know that one given up for lost cannot be healed, and that the shameless man, sinking into the depths, scorns [the remedy] with astonishing rashness. Yet I believe that even in such men counsel lives on — even in the death of their evil way of life — and that a man may wish for another what he has himself already lost. Now I shall rightly say to you with the prophet: *All that this people says is a conspiracy; and do not fear their fear, neither be dismayed.* Let there depart from us that itch of tongues which is in you, whom the same prophet truly reproves: *Writing injustice, you have written [it].* We do not, as you say, judge that blessed Peter received from the Lord, together with the privileges of the see, a licence to sin — nor that his successors did. He sent to his posterity the perpetual endowment of his merits along with an inheritance of innocence: what was granted to him for the brightness of his deeds pertains to those whom a like splendour of conduct illumines. For who would doubt that he is holy whom the summit of so great a dignity exalts — in whom, if the goods acquired by [personal] merit be lacking, those supplied by the see’s predecessor suffice? For [God] either raises to these heights men already illustrious, or illumines those who are raised; for he foreknows what is suited to the foundation of the churches, [the one] upon whom the very mass [of the building] rests. But hence you suppose that by your deeds the heavenly power is put under obligation, because to the protection of the blessed apostle you lend, as you say, a helping right hand. Do you not know, you dolts, that the sun is not helped by torches, and that lamps are not lit to aid the light of day? For it is written: *God searches the hearts and reins.*

The Laurentian objection: ‘why was he brought to trial?’ — with the canon of Carthage (pp. 297–298)

But there follows a knot [tied] with a riddle, which by I know not what art of unravelling we are to loose. For, having entered the sea of Ciceronian profundity, they send our little skiff across the uncertain shallows by the blasts of their questionings. Yet in it, with Christ holding the tiller, I shall make harbour and shall sift out point by point all your whirlwinds, having in their conduct a capacity not my own. For they say: “If the bishops’ assertion is true — that the president of the apostolic see was never subject to the judgment of inferiors — why was he brought to trial under strict summons?” Much indeed does our aged infancy labour here, to which He must be called as advocate who, unconquerable, ever masters along with us the weight of the proposition — since plainly, on behalf of the priests, I cry out with the prophet: *Shall the axe boast against him who cuts with it? or shall the saw exalt itself against him who draws it?* — so that that divine oracle may be a support to me: *As, when the exactor has ceased, the tribute rests, so has the Lord broken the staff of the impious. Grant, O Lord, what you have foretold concerning them, that as the drunken and vomiting man staggers, so may the unbeliever perish who acts faithlessly.* For this cause the prophet, mocking you, cries aloud: *Hear the word of the Lord, you men of derision.* Would anyone decree the outcome of cases from fore[p. 298]]knowledge, and, being about to set a term to raging conflicts, so measure [them] that a swift decision — while it is known to have priority in [conducting] the inquiry — should [thereby] draw on itself the charge of partiality on the decider’s part? Now, for a little while, though unworthy in speech, in deeds, and in years, I shall arraign you with pontifical voice. We — who have willed that our statutes should not rest on you upon a single scale, for whom canons have been enacted concerning the character of assailants, among whom it is unlawful to overstep the hoary decrees of the fathers, for whom it is written in the Council of Carthage (which the authority of the apostolic see approved through the bishop Faustinus, who, sent by it, was then present) that *accusers coming forth from the house of the enemy are not to be believed* — among whom a neighbourhood kindled with hatred rouses up, through dry fuel, the flame of persecution, and by secret arrangement, with expense and interlocking contrivances, composes the whole fabric of its deceit: [we,] how could our assembly have known who these men were, whom such a house would spew forth, unless they were present — and the character of the assault, whence [could we have learned it] except from the written accusation? — in which [assembly] it would have recognized the bilge-water of their crimes, while under pretence they allege that they owe the persecution to [some other men’s] crimes? After the matters brought forward concerning the accusers, you added that [the reason] why persons were ordered to be produced — persons whom the imperial authority had often demanded — pertains to the defrauding of the dignity of him who now sits in the apostolic see as though in a certain citadel.

The testimony of the world, the devoted Roman plebs, and the citadel of the churches (pp. 306–307)

But, mindful of my promise, let us touch on all the things which we recall were inserted into their work. Pope Symmachus is arraigned with a most brilliant pen, [asking] why, forestalling the assembly, he entered the examination with throngs of the people, and afterwards, when he had been summoned four times, spurned the proceedings. Has the love of truth so departed from you that you think the testimony of the world is muffled in mists of lies, and believe that words painted with the brush of falsehood have more force than the truth which Rome retains? Did he, then, approach the trial as an intruder, or,

being awaited, flee it? Did not that multitude of the people devoted to God — not [as you allege, from anything other than] Christian zeal for the faith — [[p. 307]] was it not expectation rather than fury that summoned them? Does anyone running to inflict violence have tears for companions, and does one who strives to be an object of dread show the face of one who is afraid? That multitude, joined to the priest's offices, brought to us laments, not javelins; it came not menacing with weapons but pitiable with weeping — about only to weigh down your indictment by its very display, since with the teeming rivers of its eyes it showed how lamentable, through your harshness, was the condition of the stricken one, and, amid the sobriety of a venerable examination, by its own affliction it commended him whom it could not [commend] by [spoken] voice. But you have it manifest from this very thing what it is that kindles the bile of fury: that he came to the proceedings all but acquitted — he for whom the world weeps — and that, while by your talk you heap up against the aforesaid an odium foreign to the facts, for a little while the neck, long haughty, is bowed before our reverence. For you convoke the sacred congregation only then, when you wish to make out our Symmachus a destroyer, and by a cruel piety you think it adds to our honour that he lost [it] while seated in the citadel of the churches. These things we not only did not perceive: we perceive the very opposite. Turn the poisons of your “protection” rather upon others. He has no testimony of a defender who lends the compliance of his lips to one who resists him; he loses the favour of a benefit — which he supposes it to be — who bestows anything on the unwilling, for it is no gift unless it be one you are willing to accept.

The communion argument: separated in body only — the pope's name never dropped (pp. 311–312)

Next, in place of the torments of the [judicial] examinations, you allege that the venerable bishops Laurentius and Petrus suspended themselves from the pope's communion, and whatever the caution of those convoked provided for, you construe as a charge against the accused. Was there, then, ever a time when, while the sacred rites of the Masses were being celebrated by them, there was any ceasing from the commemoration of his name? Did the aforesaid bishops ever, to suit your desires, offer half-complete sacrifices without the Catholic rite and the hoary custom? Was there ever — a thing to be charged against your own head — an offence committed against God through the [Eucharistic] thanksgiving, and did the mother-oblation come forth [as] a nurse of pardon for sin? They were indeed separated only in bodily assembly, those of whom you speak; yet they did not shun the presence of souls. If [[p. 312]] you think those men severed from mutual fellowship whom the clasp of religion joins, biting with a loving tooth, [then your] disposition has led you far from the Catholic estimation of faults. The dwelling-place of the heavenly mandate either joins us or separates us: it matters not what intervals sunder us, if we are held within one chamber in the abode above. Truly from this we infer that you are slaves of the belly and of the body, and by this baseness of your judgment you declare yourselves to be earthly chattels. For it is written: *The animal [i.e. natural] man does not perceive the things that are of the Spirit.*

THE CROWN: the prelate of this see reserved to God's own judgment (pp. 315–316)

Let us see whether any defence remains from the [objection] about regular procedure. “The visitors,” they say, “he appointed for other bishoprics too, and it is just that he be held bound by the law of his own act.” I do not attack you under this heading [[p. 316]]

of falsehood; I do not long refute words that cling to lies. Yet I say: the giver of a law is not bound by the terms of his own definition unless he wills [to be]; and unless the prince moderates [the law] from the summit of [his] eminence, he is called in vain to that right which he [himself] has granted. It is a law of probity and of the mind [i.e. an inner law] that chastises a living man even without [written] law: he devotes himself properly to [good] conduct who owes no discipline to compulsion. Other men's cases God may perhaps have willed to be settled through men: the prelate of this see he reserved, without question, to his own judgment. He willed that the successors of the blessed apostle Peter should owe their innocence to heaven alone, and should present a conscience inviolate to the probing of the most subtle examiner. Do not suppose that those souls have no dread of inquisitors, whom God has reserved before all others to his own examination. Before him the accused has no help from the polish of his pleading, since he uses as witness of deeds the very one whom [he has] as judge. You might perhaps say: such will be the condition of all souls in that [final] disputation. I shall reply that it was said to one [alone]: *You are Peter, and upon this rock I will build my church, and whatsoever you shall loose upon earth shall be loosed also in heaven*; and, again, that by the voice of holy pontiffs the dignity of his see was made venerable throughout the whole world — since to it whatever is of the faithful everywhere is subjected, since it is designated the head of the whole body — [the see] of which it seems to me to have been said through the prophet: *If she is brought low, to whose aid will you flee, and where will you leave your glory?*

The apostle Peter's prosopopoeia: Rome, head of the world, cast down; the see, nurse of the pontificate (pp. 323–324)

“The remaining heads of your objections I shall not unroll: it is better that things deserving condemnation be buried in silence. He confers nobility on crimes who transmits the fanning-abroad of them to later ears by manifold retelling. The saying of blessed Paul is to be followed, who admonishes all through his disciple and cries: *Avoid empty questionings*. For there are many things in your propositions which the love of sinning so embraces with filthy arms that they become unworthy of mention; more of them frivolity dishonours, while, the [proper] weights being withdrawn, your words are gutted, and out of religious matters a windy diction is composed, having obtained a gravity suited [only] to the ear — a diction which, amid an abundance of chaff, will bring nothing of wheat into the granaries, while it brings [[p. 324]] forth a fertility barren of the stalks' fruit and lies to the farmers with a hope [drawn] from the rankness of the grass. Those [ears] in which the winnowing-fans find nothing of profit owed to the fire and destined to perish by burning: of these it is written: *The men slept their sleep, and found nothing*. Nothing, dearest ones, is sweeter than peace — provided a heart full of bitterness does not shut out its savour. I ought indeed to have made a briefer admonition; but a not-small regard for you, and a brow long exercised amid your wranglings, has drawn it out at length. It is the way of things that many who sin are not corrected by strict address, and that in the words of the admonisher they demand that same excess which they had in their misdeeds. For me it is enough to have obeyed both your diligence and the heavenly commands. In what is to follow I shall leave no room for [my own] words, because I report these things: that Rome, the head of the world, is cast down through your designs, and that the see, the nurse of the pontificate, sees itself despised as though the lowest seat.”